were to choose isolationism, the rest of the world is likely to come knocking for resources or markets. Well before India settled into large kingdoms and empires, it engaged naturally in trade with far-flung regions of the world. Even before the arrival of Europeans, the direct material contact with India could be felt as far away as Alexandria and Astrakhan, Samarkand and Xinjiang, Luoyang and Lombok, Axum and Zanzibar. Commercial considerations invited interest from parties across the Afro–Eurasian landmass, from the European colonial powers after Vasco da Gama's voyage in 1498, and from much of the modern world after the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. The nature of Indian commercial exchange also changed over time, from rare commodities, to manufactured goods such as textiles, to services provided by Indian labour.

Taken together, power politics and international commerce have particular implications for India in the maritime domain. Until the Mughal Empire, India could afford to be focused on terrestrial preoccupations as the Indian Ocean was never dominated by any one party. Chola expansionism into maritime south and southeast Asia represented an aberration in Indian maritime history, which was otherwise characterized primarily by commercial activity and coastal defence. However, the effective British monopoly in the Indian Ocean after the Carnatic Wars turned the tables, enabling almost two centuries of British dominance on the subcontinent. India must therefore take pains to ensure that the Indian Ocean is not similarly dominated by a single actor in the future. A failure to do so could have incredibly damaging consequences for Indian security and sovereignty.

Third, the long history of India's external interactions shows the importance of establishing, shaping, and enforcing international norms that advance Indian interests. In any competitive enterprise, such as a sport, it is always advantageous for a player to also define the rules and act as a referee. This explains why all major powers have attempted to establish norms, even if they were only partially enforceable or selectively enforced. In the pre-modern world, such norms were almost always more of an ideal than an actual practice. Major historical empires, such as the Umayyad and